

Against Curricular Adjudication: A Response to Rochon and Rossi

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Abstract

[Rochon and Rossi \(2026\)](#) argue that neoclassical economics should no longer be taught to undergraduates. Their argument is based on the premise that neoclassical foundations are flawed and the empirical record is weak. I grant several of their empirical criticisms and reject the pedagogical conclusion they draw from them. A macroeconomic framework offers immense value to students when economists still disagree about it and when it offers explanations of important economic episodes that students can evaluate against historical evidence. It does not have to have been judged correct. Where those disagreements remain open, removing one side from the curriculum transfers adjudication from the student to the instructor. That same argument applies to heterodox frameworks when economists are still arguing over them. Rochon and Rossi's proposal also sits in tension with their call for a more empirical economics education, since empirical reasoning requires competing explanations against which evidence can be interpreted.

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1 Introduction

What macroeconomic paradigms should we expose our students to while teaching? [Rochon and Rossi \(2026\)](#) argue that neoclassical economics should no longer be taught to undergraduate students. I would argue these are the students most likely to benefit from broad exposure, before they have the chance to subscribe to any specific paradigm as they progress in their studies of economics.

[Rochon and Rossi \(2026\)](#) contend that neoclassical theory rests on unrealistic assumptions, performs poorly against important empirical evidence, and gives a misleading description of the economic system. In their paper, they conclude that continuing to teach neoclassical economics perpetuates the ‘cycle of bad economics’, and undergraduate programs would be better served by greater emphasis on data, empirical analysis, econometrics, and heterodox alternatives ([Rochon and Rossi, 2026](#), pp. 2, 11). They mean something stronger than a call for curricular pluralism. They reject the view that neoclassical economics should remain in the curriculum alongside competing traditions, and they argue that teaching it before exposing students to its flaws is ‘too confusing’ for undergraduate students encountering economics for the very first time (p. 11).

While I disagree with their position, I don’t reject every empirical criticism they raise. They make several legitimate points, including the flattening of the Phillips curve, evidence that firm investment may respond weakly to marginal changes in interest rates, and the prevalence of administered pricing ([Rochon and Rossi, 2026](#), pp. 4, 6). These findings may weaken particular claims or mechanisms associated with neoclassical macroeconomics; however, they do not establish the pedagogical conclusion that the framework should therefore disappear from undergraduate instruction. That conclusion requires a subscription to the idea that a macroeconomic framework warrants coverage only to the extent that it has been judged sufficiently correct in describing the economy, which I reject.

A macroeconomic framework adds value to the classroom when it remains part of a substantive unresolved dispute and offers a coherent explanation of economically important episodes whose implications can be evaluated against historical evidence. Teaching such a framework does not require endorsing it as a complete or universally correct description of the economy. A framework may explain some features of an episode well and others poorly. Its assumptions may be useful in one setting and restrictive in another. When students are asked to compare its implications with observed outcomes, its failures can be as informative as its successes. A better standard for educators is whether a framework can be evaluated, not whether it has already been designated correct.

When there is a substantive dispute, removing one side from the curriculum transfers

adjudication of that dispute from the student to the instructor. Students no longer encounter the competing explanation and weigh its strengths and weaknesses against the available evidence. They receive the instructor's prior judgment that the argument has already been resolved. A curriculum that excludes post-Keynesian, Austrian, institutional, or other heterodox explanations just because the instructor rejects them creates a symmetrical problem. My argument is not concerned with the protection of neoclassical economics as an orthodoxy, but whether students are given access to important unresolved arguments within the discipline and allowed to evaluate those arguments themselves.

What follows develops two implications of this principle. First, Rochon and Rossi's analogy to rejected scientific theories such as Ptolemaic astronomy carries a criterion that, applied consistently within economics, would exclude far more than they account for in their original paper. Second, their proposal is misaligned with their call for a more empirical economics education, because empirical reasoning requires competing explanations against which evidence can be interpreted.

2 Framework Qualification

Rochon and Rossi treat descriptive and empirical correctness as the threshold for determining what frameworks should be taught. If it rests on assumptions regarded as unrealistic, or generates relationships that perform poorly against the evidence, its continued presence in the curriculum becomes hard to justify. They repeatedly ask some version of why students should be taught a theory known to be false (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, p. 2). I believe this is a misguided standard. A framework can warrant serious consideration without being accepted as a complete description of the economy. What matters is whether it remains part of a substantive unresolved dispute and offers an explanation whose implications can be evaluated against observable evidence.

This is an important debate for macroeconomics instruction, where frameworks organize explanations. A framework directs attention toward particular mechanisms and implies patterns that should be visible if those mechanisms are important in a given episode. Those implications can then be compared with what is observable in the data. An explanation that performs poorly against the historical record should not be categorized as a waste of classroom time. Its failure provides information about the conditions under which the proposed mechanism is weak, incomplete, or unhelpful. And a framework that explains one feature of an episode well does not necessarily become a universal description of the macroeconomy. The appropriate conclusion can remain conditional.

Teaching a framework under this standard does not require us, as instructors, to endorse it. In Rochon and Rossi's own analysis of monetary policy, their criticism relies

on concepts such as the IS relationship, the Phillips curve, the natural rate of interest, inflation targeting, and the monetary transmission mechanism (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, pp. 6, 8). A student cannot fully understand their criticism without first understanding the framework being criticized. The same holds when explaining the behavior of economic institutions. If central bankers organize policy around a particular model of inflation or monetary transmission, that model may be necessary for explaining their decisions even if the analyst ultimately concludes that the model was wrong. Explanatory relevance and theoretical endorsement should not be conflated.

In my own courses, I describe this use of theory as treating macroeconomic frameworks as backward-looking observational frameworks. Students begin with an observed macroeconomic episode and ask how well competing frameworks account for what occurred. Each framework plays a role in directing attention toward different relationships, mechanisms, and implications that can be compared with the historical record. Retrospective analysis of observed episodes is one of the ways economists develop judgments about which mechanisms may matter in future episodes and which policy responses may therefore be appropriate.

Major macroeconomic frameworks are particularly suited to this form of analysis because they emerged from attempts to explain episodes that were themselves contested. The Great Depression, postwar inflation, stagflation, financial crises, and more recent inflationary episodes have generated competing accounts focused on different mechanisms. Students can ask what each framework would lead them to expect, whether those implications appear in the historical record, and where the explanation succeeds or fails. My point is that we should be cautious not to select a paradigm in advance. Instead, we should use competing frameworks to organize questions about what happened and why.

Once classroom consideration is understood this way, the problem with excluding one side of an unresolved dispute becomes clearer. Instructors necessarily make curricular choices. No course can include every theory, episode, or controversy in the discipline. In my own courses, I am limited to a 14-week semester, requiring that I be selective of materials. But selecting among settled questions and selecting among unresolved ones are different intellectual problems. When a dispute has been resolved by decisive evidence, excluding a superseded explanation is defensible. When a substantive dispute remains open, excluding one side because the instructor has judged it incorrect changes the intellectual task given to students.

Students who encounter competing explanations can examine their assumptions, compare their implications with evidence, and reach conclusions that reflect the strength and limitations of what they observe. When they only encounter an explanation from the instructor, it costs them the learning opportunity of these higher cognitive processes. They

may still learn the selected framework and analyze evidence within it, but they are no longer evaluating the underlying dispute. The broader intellectual judgment has already been made for them.

3 Scientific Analogies

Rochon and Rossi anticipate an obvious objection to curricular exclusion by comparing neoclassical economics with scientific theories that have been decisively rejected. They ask why economics should continue teaching a theory regarded as wrong when other disciplines no longer present geocentrism, flat-earth theories, or Ptolemaic astronomy as viable accounts of the physical world, endorsing Keen's (2021, p. 1) view that neoclassical economics should be completely replaced rather than reformed (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, p. 2). The analogy posits a criterion that a framework whose important propositions have been shown to fail against the evidence is no longer a candidate for pedagogical use, and continuing to teach it means teaching students something the discipline knows to be false.

Applied consistently within economics, that criterion removes a significant amount of theory that neither mainstream nor heterodox economists propose to remove. Take Keynes's *General Theory*. Subsequent scholarship, including scholarship within the post-Keynesian tradition, has substantially reformulated important elements of the book. Rochon and Rossi's own references show how ordinary such reformulation is. Rowthorn advanced the original conflict theory of inflation in 1977 and revised it for the *Review of Political Economy* in 2024, and the standing post-Keynesian reference they rely on throughout is titled *New Foundations* (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, p. 10). None of this reasonably suggests that students should stop encountering Keynes, or Rowthorn, or the earlier statements a research program has since revised. Understanding the *General Theory* is necessary for understanding what later Keynesians and their critics were arguing about and why subsequent models took the forms they did.

What this exposes is a dilemma in the criterion rather than a difficulty in applying it. If teaching something 'we know to be false' requires that every proposition in a framework has been refuted, no macroeconomic framework qualifies and the criterion excludes nothing. If it requires only that important propositions have been substantially qualified by later evidence and argument, the criterion reaches frameworks that Rochon and Rossi themselves treat as indispensable, including their own. Their argument against neoclassical economics does not distinguish between these readings, and neither reading supports the conclusion they draw.

Their treatment of the Phillips curve highlights this difficulty. They argue that the

relationship has flattened to the point of empirical insignificance and that this failure is among the strongest reasons for abandoning the framework in which it sits (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, p. 6). Yet their own exposition of conflict inflation proceeds by contrast with it. They introduce the post-Keynesian account by distinguishing it from the traditional Phillips curve framework and its posited trade-off between unemployment and inflation, and their preceding section sets out the neoclassical and expectational theories of inflation before rejecting them (pp. 9–10). A student who has never encountered those relationships cannot follow the argument that replaces them. The propositions they regard as failed are doing instructional work in their own paper.

Whether the earth occupies a particular position in the astronomical system has a determinate answer, and once observation settled it there was nothing further for competing explanations to contest. Individual economic propositions can have determinate truth conditions in the same way, and some have been settled by evidence. But a macroeconomic framework is not a single proposition. It combines abstractions, behavioral assumptions, institutional descriptions, and conditional relationships whose performance varies across periods and institutional settings. Showing that particular relationships within a framework fail does not show that the framework is false in the way geocentrism is false, because there is no dominant claim for that verdict to attach to.

Rochon and Rossi could argue that their criterion concerns foundations rather than particular propositions, and that neoclassical economics fails at its core in a way other traditions do not. However, identifying foundational commitments does not by itself establish a criterion for curricular exclusion. They would still need to show why the failure of those commitments warrants removing the framework rather than teaching it critically. What their argument does instead is accumulate failures of particular relationships, including the IS relationship, the interest sensitivity of investment, price flexibility, and the Phillips curve, and treat the accumulation as an indictment of the whole.

The relationships Rochon and Rossi dispute remain active subjects of empirical research and disagreement across economics, and their own citations show that the disagreement is not confined to heterodox critics resisting a settled consensus. They draw on Federal Reserve Board research questioning the interest sensitivity of investment (Sharpe and Suarez, 2014), work from the Bank for International Settlements questioning the responsiveness of inflation to labor market slack (Borio, 2017), and Federal Reserve research challenging the empirical foundations of the expectations-inflation relationship (Rudd, 2022), each cited in Rochon and Rossi (2026, pp. 6, 11). Questions settled in the manner of geocentrism do not ordinarily require this kind of continuing adjudication.

4 Symmetry and Scope

None of this is a defense of neoclassical economics as the default or privileged framework of undergraduate economics. Nor do I claim that their arguments lacked merit. The same principle that challenges Rochon and Rossi's proposed exclusion of neoclassical economics also challenges a conventional curriculum that presents mainstream macroeconomics while excluding serious heterodox alternatives. If post-Keynesian, Austrian, institutional, or other frameworks remain part of substantive unresolved disputes and offer explanations that can be evaluated against evidence, they warrant pedagogical consideration under the same standard.

Mainstream economics has historically occupied a dominant position in undergraduate instruction, while heterodox approaches have often received substantially less attention. [Mearman \(2017\)](#), for example, notes that most undergraduate economics teaching remains orthodox and that opportunities to teach exclusively heterodox material are limited. To the extent that conventional instruction presents one side of genuinely unresolved economic disputes as settled, the principle developed here already supports correcting that limitation through serious engagement with competing heterodox explanations. I want the curriculum broadened. What I object to is correcting one form of prior adjudication by installing another.

Excluding post-Keynesian explanations because a mainstream instructor considers them wrong and excluding neoclassical explanations because a heterodox instructor considers them wrong carry the same underlying cost. Either way, students encounter only the side of an unresolved argument that the instructor has already judged more persuasive. The principle developed here therefore does not depend on which tradition currently occupies the dominant position. It depends on whether the underlying economic dispute remains substantively open.

This argument is related to, but distinct from, recent work in *Advances in Economics Education* advocating broader and more critical treatment of economic theory. [Jahangir \(2025\)](#) develops a critical microeconomics curriculum that combines neoclassical theory with heterodox perspectives. [Cauvel et al. \(2024\)](#) argue that standard microeconomics instruction can omit or distort issues in ways that produce ideological conclusions. [Docherty \(2025\)](#) develops a post-Keynesian macroeconomic model designed for comparison with a New Keynesian model and argues that comparing the alternatives can strengthen students' critical skills. What I supply here is a different criterion for such inclusion. Heterodox frameworks do not warrant instructional time because representation or pluralism is desirable, but because they remain participants in substantive unresolved economic disputes and provide competing explanations that students can evaluate against evidence.

Therefore, representation should not be the final pedagogical criterion. A framework does not belong in the curriculum based on representing a school of thought. Further, not every tradition requires equal time. Instructional allocation should follow from the substantive economic argument. The amount of attention given to competing frameworks can differ across topics and episodes because their relevance, explanatory reach, and empirical support differ.

Applied consistently, this principle produces a curriculum in which students encounter disagreement rather than one organized around the instructor's preferred resolution of that disagreement. It asks instructors to distinguish teaching an argument from endorsing it, and selecting material from settling open questions on behalf of students.

5 Empirical Reasoning

Rochon and Rossi specifically argue that undergraduate economics should move toward greater emphasis on data, empirical analysis, econometrics, and stock-flow-consistent approaches (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, p. 11). That recommendation reasonably places empirical reasoning at the center of their preferred curriculum. But empirical reasoning requires more than exposure to data.

Evidence becomes informative when it is evaluated against explanations that generate different expectations about what should be observed. If competing explanations are removed before students encounter the evidence, the empirical exercise has already been consequentially narrowed. This is akin to deciding which explanations students are permitted to bring to the evidence. The evidence may still be analyzed carefully, but it is no longer being used to make a judgment among the full set of serious competing accounts. In that sense, the curriculum cannot produce the empirical reasoning Rochon and Rossi advocate, because the most consequential act of empirical judgment has already been performed by the instructor.

This is abundantly clear when the evidence itself remains contested. Rochon and Rossi discuss the empirical strength of the Phillips curve, the interest sensitivity of investment, monetary transmission, inflation expectations, endogenous money, and competing explanations of inflation (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, pp. 6, 8, 11). These are the kinds of questions for which evidence acquires meaning through comparison among alternative explanations.

A flatter Phillips curve may weaken one account of inflation without identifying a unique replacement. Weak interest sensitivity may challenge a particular transmission mechanism without resolving every competing theory of monetary policy. Empirical results can narrow the range of plausible explanations without necessarily settling the

broader dispute. Teaching students to reason empirically therefore requires preserving the distinction between evidence that challenges a framework and evidence that conclusively eliminates it.

Rochon and Rossi also argue that retaining neoclassical economics while subsequently exposing students to its flaws would be ‘too confusing’ for undergraduates encountering economics for the very first time (Rochon and Rossi, 2026, p. 11). That claim is striking in light of both their earlier work and the economics-education literature. Rochon and Rossi (2022) presented heterodox lessons on macroeconomic policy as useful ideas around which to generate debate in undergraduate teaching about orthodox perspectives, and described such debate as intellectually healthy and beneficial to teaching. More broadly, whether students can successfully engage competing perspectives has itself been examined in the economics education literature.

Harvey (2011), surveying students across several sections of a Contending Perspectives in Economics course, reports greater enthusiasm and confidence among students exposed to pluralist instruction, though he also finds some evidence that students remained influenced by the instructor’s own school of thought. Lapidus (2011) documents genuine difficulties students can experience in understanding competing theoretical frameworks and becoming comfortable with uncertainty. Mearman (2017), drawing in part on Earl (2000), similarly cautions that comparative reasoning cannot be forced too quickly and argues that systematic comparative treatment is preferable to sporadic exposure to competing perspectives.

Admittedly, the evidence is mixed and does not establish that comparative teaching always works. However, it does establish that student confusion is itself an empirical pedagogical question and that the answer appears conditional rather than categorical. Rochon and Rossi’s 2026 article gives extensive theoretical and empirical reasons for rejecting neoclassical economics, but it does not engage this literature before concluding that exposing introductory students to the framework and its criticisms is too confusing. Their pedagogical recommendation therefore appears to follow mainly from their judgment that the framework is wrong rather than from evidence that students cannot productively engage competing explanations, which is the inference I am challenging here.

Taken on its own terms, the confusion objection also reaches beyond neoclassical economics. Critical economic reasoning routinely requires students to learn an explanation, understand its assumptions and implications, and then examine where it succeeds and fails. If introductory students cannot do that without becoming confused, the problem is not specific to neoclassical theory. The same objection would apply to teaching post-Keynesian, institutional, Austrian, or any other framework alongside competing evidence and criticism.

The alternative creates a different problem. Students taught only endogenous money, conflict inflation, or other preferred heterodox explanations will run into mainstream macroeconomic claims as soon as they leave the classroom. Central bank communications, financial journalism, policy debates, and many professional settings continue to rely on concepts such as monetary transmission, inflation expectations, the Phillips curve, and the natural rate. A curriculum that prepares students to engage those claims has to teach them critically, which returns to the comparative exercise Rochon and Rossi regard as too confusing. A curriculum that does not prepare students to engage them leaves students less able to understand and evaluate the economic arguments they will actually encounter.

Framing this as clarity versus confusion would be a mischaracterization of the choice. Students are either equipped to engage unresolved economic disagreement or insulated from part of it by prior curricular judgment. The first requires comparison, criticism, and evidence. The second risks turning empirical education into reasoning within a framework whose admissibility has already been decided for the student.

6 Conclusion

Rochon and Rossi are right to insist that economics education should take empirical evidence seriously. Where I disagree is with the conclusion they draw from that commitment. Evidence that weakens a framework does not establish that the framework should be removed from undergraduate economics. This is especially true when the underlying dispute remains substantively open. In that setting the framework still warrants instructor consideration, as its explanations can be compared with competing accounts and evaluated against the historical record.

Excluding one side of an unresolved dispute not only changes course content, it transfers the most important intellectual judgment for critical evaluation from the student to the instructor. A curriculum that excludes post-Keynesian or other heterodox explanations because a mainstream instructor considers them wrong creates the same problem as one that excludes neoclassical explanations because a heterodox instructor has reached the opposite judgment. Either way, students inherit the instructor's resolution of an argument that remains open within economics.

Removing a framework from the curriculum altogether also carries a disciplinary cost. Economic traditions are not only collections of propositions; they are parts of the intellectual history through which major economic problems have been interpreted and contested. Students who encounter only the surviving or preferred explanation lose access to part of that argumentative record. They lose the opportunity to evaluate why an

earlier framework was persuasive, which observations challenged it, or how competing approaches developed in response. Criticizing a framework preserves that history while subjecting it to scrutiny. Excluding it removes part of the argument itself.

I believe there is also a broader danger. The strength of an economic conclusion should reflect the strength of the evidence supporting it. When contested theoretical and empirical claims get converted into categorical judgments about which frameworks students should be permitted to encounter, that discipline is lost. Students risk learning economics as subscription to a preferred paradigm rather than as the evaluation of competing explanations under uncertainty. On many macroeconomic questions the responsible conclusion may very well be conditional. Preserving that uncertainty is part of economic reasoning rather than a weakness of it.

For these reasons, a framework that performs poorly against some evidence should remain in the classroom. Further, neoclassical economics should remain. Its weaknesses should be exposed, its explanation compared with serious alternatives, and students should be allowed to see where the evidence leads. Rochon and Rossi's proposal asks instructors to make that determination first and hand students the resulting judgment. I propose the argument itself should be wrestled with by the student.

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